

# Toi i te Ara — Art in the Street

Research foundation for street-based activism connected to te reo Māori, Māori data sovereignty, and kaupapa Māori art education. A companion document to Te Pā Tūwatawata.

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## SECTION 1 — MAORI STREET ART & PASTE-UP TRADITIONS IN AOTEAROA

### Origins of the Scene

The modern graffiti and street art scene in Aotearoa has deep roots in Auckland and Wellington, catalysed by two key media moments: the American graffiti documentary *Style Wars* airing on NZ television in 1984, and the book *Subway Art* by Henry Chalfant and Martha Cooper. These inspired young people — particularly Māori and Pasifika youth — to take up spray cans. A crucial early influence was the Polynesian diaspora circuit: Samoan and Tongan youth travelling to California brought back LA gang-style tagging that evolved into a distinctively Auckland street form called 'straits.'

[Te Ara — Public and Street Art](#)

### TMD — The Most Dedicated

The most influential crew in Aotearoa's history. Founded in 1997 by Phat1 (Charles Williams) and Adict from an Auckland Council-funded project where young taggers were mentored to paint two large-scale walls along the West Auckland rail corridor. TMD grew to over 35 members across Aotearoa, Australia, and Germany. Crucially, many founders are Māori and Pasifika.

| ADICT                       | Ngāpuhi                              | Core founder             |
|-----------------------------|--------------------------------------|--------------------------|
| EXIST                       | Tainui                               | Core member              |
| HASER (Kairau Bradley)      | Ngāpuhi                              | Large-scale murals       |
| LADY DIVA (Janine Williams) | Ngāti Pāoa, Ngāti Whātua ki Kaipara  | Murals, Bird Gang series |
| PHAT1 (Charles Williams)    | Ngāpuhi, Ngāi Tuhoe, Ngāti Kahungunu | Co-founder, Bird Gang    |
| RAMS                        | Ngāpuhi                              | Core member              |

[Watch This Space — TMD at the Dowse \(2021\)](#)

### Key Artists

#### Askew One (Elliot O'Donnell)

NZ's best-known street artist. Co-defined the term 'post-graffiti Pacific.' His large-scale murals use stylised slogans citing Colin McCahon as an influence: 'A lot of our key artists have always centered around graphic use of type and words. It's part of the New Zealand painting tradition.'

#### Elliot Francis Stewart (DEUS)

Tāmaki Makaurau-based TMD member. Bold colour palettes depicting intimate, serene scenes enriched with detail. Works at the Coastal Arts Trail (Whanganui), Flare Street Art Festival (Ōtautahi), and across Aotearoa.

#### Tessa Harris

Played a fundamental role establishing Māori street art and public mahi toi in Tāmaki Makaurau, including work at Te Komititanga and Silo Park.

#### Caine Taihia (Ngāti Whātua Ōrākei)

Created 11 graffiti designs for construction hoardings in central Auckland under the title Ka Tū Te Mana o Waihorotiu — connecting the city to the invisible Waihorotiu Stream and its mana and mauri.

#### Poi Ngawati (Waikato Tainui)

Created Te Huinga Tai – The gathering of tides on Auckland's Airedale Street steps — a modern Māori stylised pūhoro design in violet purple and teal.

### The Visual Language of Aotearoa Street Art

| Koru              | Unfurling fern frond; new life, growth, renewal; central to Tino Rangatiratanga flag |
|-------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Pūhoro            | Traditional curvilinear patterns; speed/status; now in contemporary mural form       |
| Whakairo elements | Stylised carvings incorporated into mural backgrounds                                |
| Tekoteko angles   | Figures posed with head angle of carved tekoteko; centering Māori assertiveness      |
| Native birds      | Kōtuku, tūī, kererū used as narrative vehicles and identity symbols                  |
| Black, red, white | The dominant activist palette — from the Tino Rangatiratanga flag                    |
| Bold graphic type | Via Colin McCahon's word-based painting tradition; text as image                     |

SECTION 2 — TE REO MAORI ACTIVIST VISUAL CULTURE

The Tino Rangatiratanga Flag

Designed in 1989 by Hiraina Marsden, Jan Dobson Smith, and Linda Munn for a Te Kawariki competition. Launched 1990, recognised by Cabinet as the preferred Māori flag in 2009.

| Black (Mangu)   | Te pō — realm of night and potential                                 |
|-----------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Red (Whero)     | Te whaiao — the world of light entering                              |
| White koru (Mā) | Te ao mārama — full light; unfurling fern frond, signifying new life |

Protest Visual Genres

From the 2024 Hikoi mō Te Tiriti (42,000+ marchers — the largest march to Parliament in NZ history), placard culture combined serious te reo Māori phrases with witty bilingual wordplay and large, bold, legible typography. Described as 'an art form' with 'the ability to communicate huge kōrero with immediacy, compel curiosity, and ask questions.'

Scoop — Signs of the Hikoi (2024)

Tame Iti — 'I Will Not Speak Maori'

2022 nationwide billboard and silk-screen poster campaign co-created with Delaney Davidson. The phrase re-weaponises what Iti was forced to write as a child (punishment for speaking te reo at school). Visual treatment: bold typographic propaganda posters echoing Soviet-era monumental graphic design — deliberately infiltrating institutional visual language. Deployed in galleries, projected onto Te Papa walls, installed on Wellington waterfront, and placed as posters across Aotearoa.

*"Making the message into monumental and corporate language, echoing Tāme's work with Billy Apple. Playing with the ideas of tapu and noa, the cliches of white and black and the sanctified idea of law."*

— Delaney Davidson. [delaneydavidson.com](https://delaneydavidson.com)

Hohepa Thompson — Everyday Language Activism

Ōtaki artist who placed te reo stickers ('Rāpihi' on bins) around the community as everyday language activism. When a neighbouring shop called te reo 'graffiti,' Thompson publicly called out the racism and created an exhibition. A direct model for sticker activism for te reo revitalisation.

Wahine Maori Activist Art — Key Visual Elements

| Black, red, white    | Te pō / te whaiao / te ao mārama — activist palette across all contexts |
|----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Pou                  | Structural images of authority and presence                             |
| Tekoteko head angles | In figurative work; Māori assertiveness                                 |
| Raukura              | White feathers on red and black backgrounds — Taranaki rohe activism    |
| Whakairo stylisation | In contemporary canvas and mural work                                   |

|                        |                                      |
|------------------------|--------------------------------------|
|                        |                                      |
| Shadows / knowing eyes | Depth of knowledge held within       |
| Flags and knots on pou | Subtle, embedded activism in details |

## SECTION 3 — INDIGENOUS STREET-BASED ACTIVISM GLOBALLY

### Richard Bell (Australia — Kamilaroi, Kooma, Jiman)

Self-described 'activist masquerading as an artist.' Co-founded proppaNOW (2003). Visual conventions: blunt messages in bright colours; archival photographs of activists embedded within Aboriginal-looking motifs, 'hiding a strong statement in plain view'; appropriation of cultural forms; collaboration with Emory Douglas (Black Panther Party). Key phrase: 'You don't need permission to make it happen.'

### Zapatista Mural Art (EZLN, Mexico)

The EZLN developed one of the most coherent traditions of community mural activism globally. Community-painted murals on rough wood and concrete in autonomous communities (caracoles). Key principles: anonymity (the community is the author, not the individual); text integrated into image; flat bold colour; collective production; feminist imagery. The aesthetic: 'unglamorous, persistent, slow, steady' — art as community affirmation, not spectacle.

| Caracol (snail)          | Slow, steady progress toward autonomy                  |
|--------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| Masked figure (ski mask) | Anonymity as equaliser — anyone could be the Zapatista |
| Corn / milpa             | Subsistence, Indigenous agriculture, community life    |
| Short declarative text   | 'Here the people command and the government obeys'     |
| Flat bold colour         | Strong black outlines, limited palette, high contrast  |

### Idle No More (Canada / Indigenous North America, 2012–)

Visual conventions: sacred circle / medicine wheel (four directions, four colours); water as central motif ('water is life' / Nibi imagery); eagle feathers and traditional regalia. Christi Belcourt (Anishinaabe) and Isaac Murdoch produced banner art for mass demonstrations, sending them to water protection actions across North America for free.

### Standing Rock / NoDAPL (2016–2017)

'Water is Life' / Mni Wiconi as the key slogan. 'Protector' framing — shared with Ihumātao and Mauna Kea. Photography-based protest art amplified globally via social media. Bold colour — black, earth tones, blues; high contrast for sticker and poster reproduction. Te Papa notes that the Ihumātao poster situates itself within this international 'protector' discourse.

## SECTION 4 — ART PEDAGOGY FRAMEWORKS FOR STREET ACTIVISM

### Paulo Freire — Conscientizacao and Street Art

Freire commissioned artists to create 'coded pictures' — visual materials as pedagogical prompts to trigger literacy and political consciousness simultaneously. He argued any artwork could be used as a 'problem-posing' tool. Applied to street art: murals and stickers function as 'public textbooks.' The key principle: art as street curriculum making injustice visibly present, prompting spontaneous dialogue without requiring institutions or teachers.

*"To surmount the situation of oppression, people must first critically recognize its causes, so that through transforming action they can create a new situation."*

— Paulo Freire, *Pedagogy of the Oppressed* (1970)

Key Freirean design principle: Don't 'deposit' a message into a community without consultation (the 'banking pedagogy' trap). Design for questions, not just declarations. Te Kotahitanga (2001–2013), the highly successful kaupapa Māori educational programme, was explicitly grounded in Freire's philosophy.

### Diego Rivera — Muralism as Public Pedagogy

Rivera's mural programme at the Secretaria de Educacion Publica (SEP), Mexico City, 1920s: 'The people as heroes' — Rivera initiated 'the true novelty of Mexican painting by making the people the heroes of mural painting.' Art should be public and political — art confined to galleries serves only the elite. Revolutionary iconography: armed workers, raised fists, historical liberation figures. Functional setting — murals in education ministries, hospitals, universities: art embedded where people live and learn.

### Kaupapa Maori Art Education

Whatu pedagogy (Unitec, Toi Ako): Whatu (finger weft-twining) theorised as Māori arts pedagogy — not just practice or product but a set of ideas and theory. 'I do not teach Kahukura to whatu. She watches, she talks, she sings. The pedagogy at work here is not teaching. It is education.' — Hinekura Smith. Ako and tuakana-teina: reciprocal learning relationships — teacher is also learner; shift from individual meritocracy to collective benefit.

Three criteria for Māori pedagogy (Penetito):

| A sense of belonging to place                 | Art rooted in the whenua where it is made                           |
|-----------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Relationship of cohabitators with environment | Art about the relationships between people and land                 |
| Embodying ways of knowing and being           | Art that embodies matauranga — a conscious union of mind and spirit |

## SECTION 5 — STICKER ACTIVISM: TECHNICAL CONVENTIONS

### Standard Sizes

| A6 / postcard     | 105 × 148 mm     | Most common small sticker; pocket-sized hand distribution |
|-------------------|------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| A5                | 148 × 210 mm     | Lamp posts, utility boxes                                 |
| Circle (small)    | 75–100 mm diam.  | Badge size; laptop, bag, helmet                           |
| Circle (medium)   | 100–150 mm diam. | Good street sticker; visible without being oversized      |
| Rectangle die-cut | 90 × 55 mm       | Bulk printing; low cost; high density distribution        |
| Rectangle wide    | 200 × 100 mm     | Text + image; readable at 2–3 metres                      |
| Vinyl die-cut     | Custom shape     | Most durable; contour-cut following image shape           |
| Wheatpaste small  | A4 / A3          | Cheapest mass format; 3–10 cents/sheet                    |
| Wheatpaste medium | A2 (420×594mm)   | Standard political poster size                            |
| Wheatpaste large  | A1 (24×36")      | High-visibility wall-scale paste-up                       |

### Design Principles for Street Stickers and Wheatpaste

| Legibility         | 1-inch letters readable from 10 feet. Bold, thick letterforms essential. Minimum 2-3 inches text height for outdoor use.   |
|--------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Contrast           | Black on white, white on black, white on red, black on yellow. Blues and blacks most UV-resistant outdoors.                |
| Simplicity         | 'Go big, go simple.' Avoid gradients, halftones, complex shading — these reduce contrast and fail at small sizes.          |
| Wheatpaste         | Black and white primary palette. Huge headline + strong central image + URL/QR. Apply paste underneath and over the top.   |
| Weather resistance | Vinyl standard for weather resistance. UV-blocking lamination extends outdoor lifespan. Round corners reduce edge-peeling. |
| Colour strategy    | Max 3 colours. Tino Rangatiratanga palette (red/black/white) reads immediately as Maori activist context.                  |

### Production Cost Reference

| A4/A3 B&W; photocopy         | 3–10 cents/sheet — cheapest mass format        |
|------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| Vinyl die-cut stickers       | ~\$0.30–\$0.80 each in bulk for simple designs |
| Wheatpaste flour-water paste | Essentially free — flour + water + bucket      |



## SECTION 6 — KEY TE REO PHRASES FOR MAORI STREET PROTEST

All phrases below are drawn from documented real protest contexts — land marches, hikoi, occupations, language petitions, and data sovereignty activism.

### Land Rights & Sovereignty

| Toitū te whenua                      | The land endures forever                                 | Ihumatao, Bastion Point, Waikato contexts |
|--------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| Ko au te whenua, ko te whenua, ko au | I am the land, and the land is me                        | Bastion Point occupation                  |
| Mana whenua                          | Authority over the land; people who hold mana in a place | Virtually all Maori protest materials     |
| Fletcher, whakahokia mai te whenua   | Fletcher, return the land                                | Ihumatao banners                          |

### Treaty & Constitutional Rights

| Toitū Te Tiriti       | The Treaty endures / Honour the Treaty                   | Central slogan of 2024 Hikoi mo Te Tiriti          |
|-----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| Tino Rangatiratanga   | Full chieftainship / absolute self-determination         | All protest contexts from 1840 to present          |
| Mana Motuhake         | Self-determination; separate authority; independent mana | Used interchangeably with Tino Rangatiratanga      |
| Ka whawhai tonu matou | We will fight on forever (ake, ake, ake)                 | Waikato war cry; affirms ongoing resistance        |
| Kotahitanga           | Unity; collective solidarity                             | Core value of 2024 hikoi; banners, posters, chants |

### Language Rights

| Ko te reo te mauri o te mana Maori | The language is the life force of the mana of Maori     | Sir James Henare, 1988                    |
|------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| Ka ngaro te reo, ka ngaro tatou    | If the language is lost, we will be lost (like the moa) | Language petitions, Waitangi Tribunal     |
| Akona te reo Maori                 | Learn the Maori language                                | Protest posters from the 1970s            |
| He waka eke noa                    | We are all in this together                             | Wellington Women's March 2017; 2024 hikoi |

### Data Sovereignty

| Raraunga hei taonga                         | Data as treasure                        | Te Mana Raraunga core framing             |
|---------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| Rangatiratanga o te raraunga                | Sovereignty over data                   | Direct parallel to Tino Rangatiratanga    |
| Ko a matou raraunga, ko matou ano           | Our data, ourselves                     | Data as extension of identity and mana    |
| Kaitiakitanga raraunga                      | Data guardianship / stewardship         | Responsible Maori data governance         |
| Tino rangatiratanga i roto i te ao hangarau | Self-determination in the digital world | For Maori technology sovereignty activism |

## SECTION 7 — CROSS-CUTTING DESIGN OBSERVATIONS

### What Works for Street Stickers in This Context

| Black + red + white only        | The Tino Rangatiratanga palette. Immediately legible as Maori activist context. UV-resistant black base; red as urgency/fire; white as clarity. |
|---------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Macron-correct te reo           | The macron itself is an activist statement. Its presence asserts linguistic sovereignty.                                                        |
| Single central image + phrase   | Koru, pou, waka, taiaha, taniwha, hand-over-whenua — clean silhouette forms at sticker scale.                                                   |
| Bold sans-serif or stencil type | No thin fonts. No decorative scripts. Type that reproduces cleanly at 20mm height.                                                              |
| Bilingual design                | Te reo large / English small, or te reo only for audience-aware distribution.                                                                   |
| Round corners                   | On all sticker formats — reduces edge peeling and extends outdoor life.                                                                         |
| Vinyl substrate                 | For any sticker intended for long-term outdoor placement.                                                                                       |

### Motifs with Strong Activist Lineage

| Koru                                | New life; language revitalisation; Tino Rangatiratanga flag centre      |
|-------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Taiaha / patu                       | Self-determination; protection of land; warrior tradition of resistance |
| Waka                                | Collective action; 'He waka eke noa'; journey to Parliament (hikoi)     |
| Taniwha                             | Guardianship of waterways; spiritual authority over land and water      |
| Maunga silhouette                   | 'Ko [maunga] ko au'; mountain as ancestor; land sovereignty             |
| Cupped hands over whenua            | Land protection (Ihumatao poster); kaitiakitanga                        |
| Tino Rangatiratanga koru            | Sovereignty; independence; universal Maori protest signifier            |
| Binary / data motif (0s+1s as koru) | Maori data sovereignty; 'raraunga hei taonga'                           |
| Eye within whakairo                 | 'Seeing the world through te ao Maori'; resistance through knowledge    |

Drawing from Freire and Rivera: the image should pose a problem, not just make a statement. Stickers that create dissonance between official reality and lived reality are more politically active than stickers that celebrate. The best Māori activist art — from Tāme Iti's billboard reversals to Hohepa Thompson's 'Rāpihi' bin stickers — creates a cognitive interruption in the viewer's everyday reading of public space. Art that asks 'Why?' is more powerful than art that says 'Look at this.'

## Sources

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